

AuthorsLab Pricing Research

Report V1

AL-SIS-PRR-001 · 2026-07-28 · SIS – System Admin · For: AL Pricing Chat (founding input)

Deep-research harness: 25 sources fetched, 111 claims extracted, 25 verified by 3-vote adversarial panel — **25 confirmed**, **0 refuted**. Site review closed by direct fetch. Confidence stated per finding.

1 · Headline answer

£19/month (~\$24) sits squarely mid-market for individual writers: between Sudowrite's Hobby (\$10–19/mo) and Professional (\$22–29/mo) tiers, ~2.3–3% of a working UK/indie author's median income, and well inside the ~\$81+/month even low-earning indies report spending on marketing. But the writer market is **bimodal and price-sensitive at the bottom** (44% of surveyed indies earn ≤\$100/month from books; median all-author book income \$2,000/yr US, £7,000 UK and falling), so a single price point is wrong — a low entry tier and a clearly higher-value professional tier are both warranted, and the imprint segment is a different SKU entirely.

2 · Competitor landscape (verified HIGH unless noted)

Product	Model	Price	Shape lesson
Sudowrite (closest AI comparable)	Credit-metered subscription, NO feature gating	Hobby \$19/mo (\$10 annual, 225k credits) · Pro \$29 (\$22, 1M) · Max \$59 (\$44, 2M + rollover)	The pattern to copy: all features on every tier, tiers = capacity
PublishDrive	Flat subscription (keep 100% royalties) + separate AI credits (60 free ≈ 1 book)	from ~\$9.99/mo · Abacus royalty tool \$1.49/title/mo	Closest precedent for OUR exact transition: subscription + credits for expensive AI ops
Reedsy	Free tooling monetizing a freelancer marketplace	Editing 80k words: \$2,160–\$5,050 · typesetting ~\$800 · total self-pub \$2,940–\$5,660	The value anchor: we are 7–17× cheaper than human services
Hederis (imprint production)	Per-title	\$119–199/title, bundles to \$159 at 24 titles	Imprint tooling prices per-title as often as per-seat
Consonance (publisher mgmt, UK)	Per-seat with minimum	£75/seat/mo, 8-seat min ≈ £600/mo + £2,500 setup	Small imprints demonstrably pay £7k+/year for editorial SaaS
Bookalope	Per-conversion credits + enterprise annual	volume-pegged	Credits-never-expire variant
Supplementary (extracted, not panel-verified — MEDIUM/LOW)	NovelCrafter \$4–20/mo (no AI on base tier) · Atticus \$147 one-time · Vellum \$199.99–249.99 one-time · Scrivener \$49 one-time · Draft2Digital ~15% commission		The prosumer bracket around £19 is thinner in verified data — closed by AL-PC-PBR-001 (2026-07-28)

3 · Willingness to pay (all HIGH, primary surveys)

- US: full-time authors median \$10k book income (\$20k all-source); ALL authors median \$2k book / \$5k total (Authors Guild 2023, n=5,699).
- UK: primary-occupation authors median **£7,000**, down 38% real-terms since 2018 (ALCS/CREATE 2022). £228/yr ≈ 3% of that income — material.
- Spend exists where commitment exists: successful indies (\$10k+/mo) pay \$250–\$1,999/book for editing; average indie marketing spend \$636/mo (~\$81 even among sub-\$100 earners; self-selected samples, likely overstated).

- ALLi: committed indies' median gross ~\$12,755 (2022), out-earning traditionally published peers.

Reading: £19/mo is low-to-mid for a committed indie, high for a hobbyist. Price the commitment, not the average.

4 · Model shape (MEDIUM — one VC playbook + live competitor practice)

Bessemer's AI Pricing Playbook (Feb 2026): hybrid — base subscription for predictability + usage/credit metering for expensive operations — wins when cost/value dynamics are uncertain. Sudowrite and PublishDrive both run this live. Cautionary tale in sources: Cursor's 2025 pricing change burned loyal users by moving the meter without grandfathering — whatever AL chooses, transition handling for the existing 11 beta authors matters.

Fit with our estate: the Imo_ledger (live 2026-07-27) will meter actual per-author, per-station COGS within weeks of Craft Call rollout — the credit allowances can be set from measured cost, not guesswork, and the financial model's COGS lines become instrument readings. Investor-grade.

5 · Current site (verified by direct fetch, 2026-07-28)

Free full-manuscript analysis + "\$299 Complete Journey" one-time; anchor message "Traditional editing costs \$2,000–\$10,000+. AuthorsLab: \$299"; five-phase journey advertised (developmental → line → copy → publishing prep → marketing); CTAs "Get Free Analysis" / "Start Your Journey – \$299".

Pivot implications: the anchor survives ("a fraction of human-services cost — every month, every project"); free analysis remains the top-of-funnel; "Complete Journey" one-time framing must become per-project capacity framing; multi-project value (the actual subscription rationale) is currently absent from the page entirely.

6 · Stress-test architecture (SYNTHESIS — validate with Van Westendorp on own audience)

- **Starter** ~£9–12/mo: 1 active project, capped analyses. (Hobbyist entry; bimodal-market answer.)
- **Author** ~£19–24/mo: multi-project, monthly deep-analysis credits, full publishing/marketing tools. Flagship — at/just above Sudowrite Pro to signal broader scope. *(Paul's £19 instinct lands here — validated as in-range, likely at the lower edge given AL spans 5 journey stages vs Sudowrite's drafting-only.)*
- **Pro** ~£39–49/mo: unlimited projects, rollover credits, priority.
- **Imprint SKU** £250–£750/mo: list-based (titles/year, Hederis pattern) or seats-with-minimum (Consonance pattern). Separate sales motion — the Jacky conversation prices against Consonance's £600/mo floor, not writer tiers.
- **Keep a one-time per-book pass** (~\$149–299) as marketplace-style entry feeding subscription conversion — the current product becomes the funnel, not a casualty.

7 · Caveats & open questions (carried honestly)

Income data is 2022-vintage (most recent primary surveys). Prosumer bracket (ProWritingAid, Atticus, NovelCrafter at panel-verified level) is the thinnest verified area — closest bracket to £19; closed by AL-PC-PBR-001 (2026-07-28). Model-shape evidence is directional, not empirical churn data. Written Word Media/ALLi samples self-select toward committed indies. All vendor prices verified live 2026-07-28 and can change. Open: does the London imprint prefer per-seat, per-title, or list pricing? (Ask them — September.)